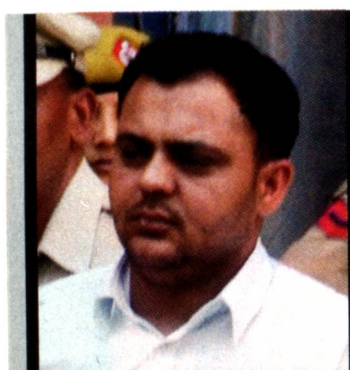


2007. The two had eloped and got married in a Chandigarh temple after their families opposed it on the ground that they shared the gotra, Banwala.

Though Manoj's family was quick to reconcile and welcome the new daughter-in-law, Babli's family and the community were less accommodating. After the couple started getting threats from the all-powerful khap panchayat as also Babli's family, they moved a Kaithal court for protection. "The court gave them protection but Manoj called us one day to say that Babli's relatives had

On July 1, 2007, Chanderpati identified the bodies of the young couple from their clothes and other belongings. They had been brutally murdered before their bodies were wrapped in gunny sacks and thrown into a canal. The killers had chased and abducted the two when they were leaving for Delhi. The court has sentenced Babli's brother Suresh, her uncles Rajinder and Baru Ram, cousins Gurdev and Satish to death and has awarded a life term to Ganga Raj, a khap leader. Mandeep Singh, the driver of the SUV in

They may have played a useful role in handling local feuds and even curbing social evils such as gambling, but in recent years they have been in the news for all the wrong reasons. These panchayats reject the provisions of the Hindu Marriage Act, which prohibits marriages among siblings but is silent on intra-gotra marriages. Khaps prohibit such intra-gotra marriages as among Jats they are considered siblings. They also bar marriages between boys and girls of different gotras even from other villages if there



SURESH, 25
Babli's brother

SENTENCED TO DEATH



SATISH, 28
Babli's cousin

SENTENCED TO DEATH



GURDEV, 34
Babli's cousin

SENTENCED TO DEATH



GANGA RAJ, 52
Khap leader

LIFE IMPRISONMENT

been chasing them and that the policemen entrusted with protecting them had left them alone, so they were leaving for Delhi. He said his cellphone had run out of balance and that we should call him. But when we called him after about an hour, his phone was switched off and there was no communication with them after that," recounts Chanderpati, Manoj's mother. Soon Babli's family proclaimed that they had killed the two. Scared, Chanderpati then lodged an FIR, but that only intensified the hostility towards her family. "Instead of supporting us, the khap panchayat announced our social boycott and said that anyone who kept relations with us would be penalised by Rs 25,000. We were not allowed to travel by bus, which is the only transport from our village to the city and other villages," recalls Manoj's cousin Narinder, who works in Panchkula.

which the couple was forcibly taken, has been sentenced to seven years in jail. The court has also indicted six police personnel for dereliction of duty.

The landmark verdict came after three years and 76 hearings during which as many as 41 witnesses deposed before the court. It is expected to put an end to the bizarre kangaroo courts that account for the murder or suicides of at least 100 boys and girls every year in Haryana. Khap—a self-proclaimed arrangement of caste lords—is an age-old system of social administration in villages of north-western India covering parts of Rajasthan, Punjab, Madhya Pradesh, Haryana and western Uttar Pradesh. A unit of khap takes care of the social affairs of almost 84 villages from the same caste.

is *bhaichara* (brotherhood) between the two gotras.

The khaps have often banished "offending" couples and their families from villages, forced them to sell their land and property, publicly disgraced their relatives, imposed hefty or symbolic fines and even ordered execution of such couples. The Punjab and Haryana High Court and even district courts regularly receive protection pleas from the victim couples of such khaps. But, despite the protection, violent incidents occur. The reason being the patronage they get from politicians, who can't annoy the khaps as they are highly effective votebanks. Chief Minister Bhupinder Singh Hooda says khaps are "a social issue, but the Government will check any law and order problem". Because khaps enjoy tremendous political clout, the police too don't dare to act against them.